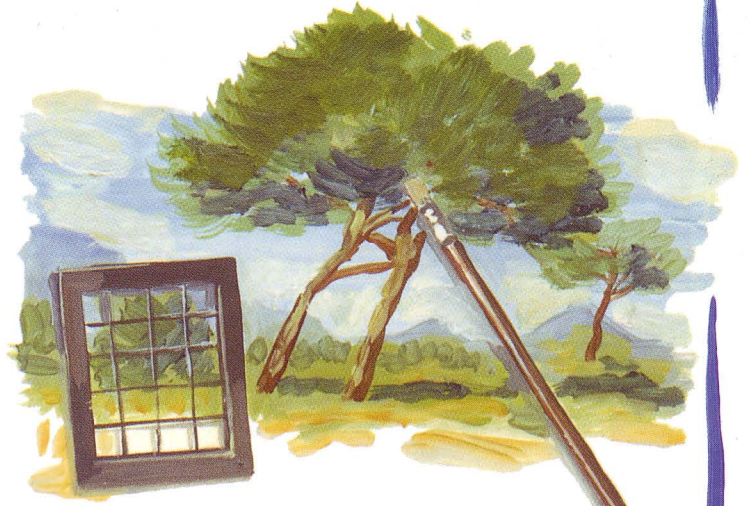


Complex arrangements

Once you have looked at individual objects on their own, you may decide to paint a more complex arrangement that includes a number of objects. Here your approach to painting can be just the same, except that you will have to make decisions about how you organize your composition. Try to establish a sense of balance between the forms. This does not mean that what you see must be staid and solid, but that there should be a link or a thread running through the arrangement that binds it together.

You should also decide what kind of visual impact you want the composition to make. A composition that fills the frame will convey a sense of boldness and generosity – or you can create a feeling of separateness or isolation by painting gaps between the objects. This kind of experimentation with simple, accessible forms can be invaluable in experimenting with styles and approaches, giving you the confidence you need before you decide to tackle the more difficult subjects of portraits and landscapes.



Visual aids

It can be helpful to use photographs for visual reference when you work on a complicated subject such as a landscape, as you have the benefit of a three-dimensional scene or object already transcribed into a flat, two-dimensional image. Try to paint freely and not to copy the image exactly as it appears, or the painting may become cramped and look awkward.

It is better to make a free transcription that leaves out all the unnecessary details and allows you to practice looking, for example, for cooler colors and lighter tones toward the horizon, which help to increase the sense of aerial perspective.

Working with confidence

When you come to work freely with any subject in any situation, the kinds of simplifications that you have practiced previously are all still entirely appropriate. When working from life, an artist needs to make a mental synthesis of the subject being painted, select the most interesting elements that will override the mass of extraneous detail, and allow the painting to develop as a succinct and self-contained world in its own right. In this way, you will learn to discover a painting style that is most suited to you, and to adapt techniques to create new and unusual effects.

